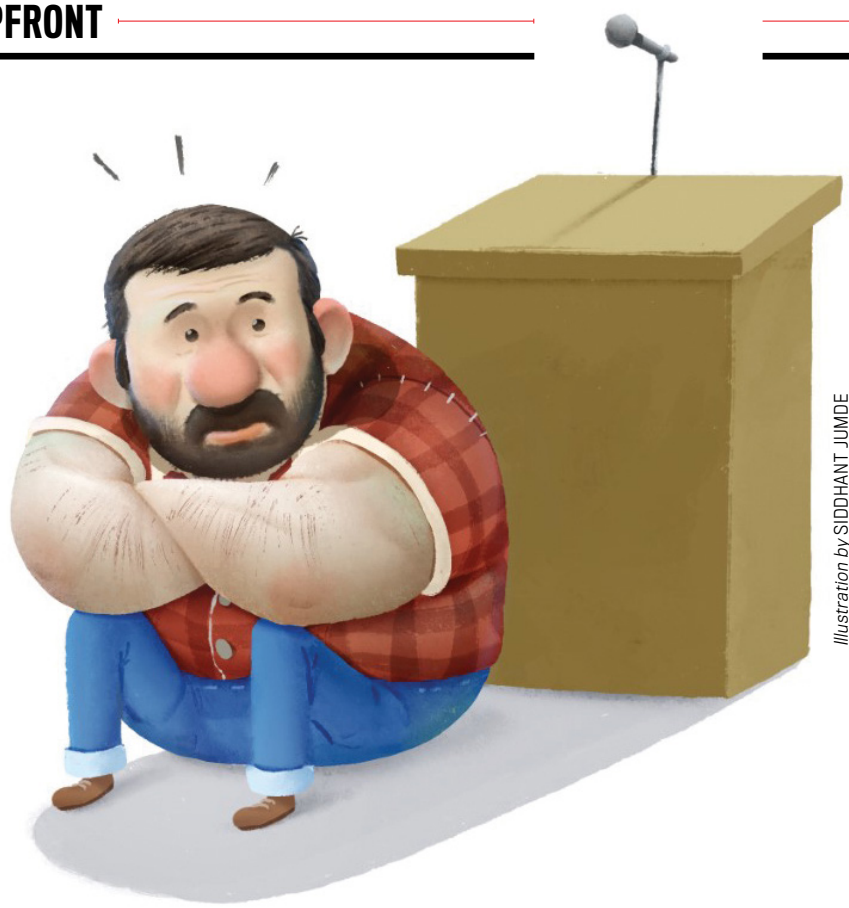


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

DEOL GOES AWOL

In 2019, the BJP roped in actor Sunny Deol as its Jat Sikh face, nominating him from Gurdaspur, where he defeated former (PPCC) Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee president Sunil Jakhar in the Lok Sabha election. No such luck for the assembly election. The star MP has not campaigned for the Punjab poll and even skipped Prime Minister Narendra Modi's rally in his constituency. He reportedly last visited Gurdaspur in September 2020. Stepmother Hema Malini, a two-term BJP MP from Mathura, on the other hand, has been drawing crowds at rallies in Amritsar and Maur. Star for star?

NATURAL ALLIES



When Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao** met his Maharashtra counterpart **Uddhav Thackeray** in Mumbai on February 21, they had two non-politicians accompanying them. What could **Tejas Thackeray** (far left in picture) the CM's younger son, and South Indian movie star **Prakash Raj** (third from right), who was part of KCR's entourage, have in common? Thackeray Jr is a wildlife researcher and Raj a nature-lover, who recently lent his voice to a TV documentary. The connect was only natural.

–Sandeep Unnithan *with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Kiran D. Tare and Romita Datta*



BANG FOR THE MEDIA BUCK

When Maharashtra finance minister Ajit Pawar recently questioned the government's Rs 200 crore annual publicity spend, the new head of the directorate general of information and publicity (DGIPR) **Deepak Kapoor** began asking why. He found 42 dormant official Twitter handles his department is running. Now he wants officials to audit their Twitter and Insta posts. A social media overhaul is on its way.

ANI



Red Remix

There was a mild cheer in West Bengal's CPI(M) when the party recently eclipsed the BJP's vote share in the Kolkata Municipal Corporation election. The Left had repurposed the '*Oo Antava*' item song from the Telugu hit *Pushpa* to target the ruling Trinamool Congress on corruption and extortion. The voters loved the parody. Encouraged, the CPI(M) now plans to use it for the upcoming municipal poll. It's game on.